BANKER ON BOARD



Some appointments are as symbolic as they are substantive, and banker **Uday Kotak's** elevation as chairman of Gujarat International Finance Tec (GIFT) City is one such. Conceived to attract global finance to India, GIFT City has steadily built an ecosystem of banks, insurers, aircraft lessors, regulators and such. Until now, it was led by retired babus, but Kotak's appointment now signals a shift toward making it more market-driven and globally competitive. After all, in finance, credibility matters as much as capital.

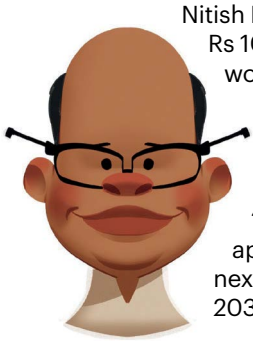
Stealth Raid



Maharashtra food minister **Narhari Zirwal** of the NCP (Ajit Pawar) got a surprise when the anti-corruption bureau landed up in his office at the state secretariat and arrested a clerk for taking a bribe. The accused is from Zirwal's home district, Nashik, but the political buzz is all about why the minister was kept in the dark and, more importantly, why the raid took place when he was away in Delhi. The timing is unusual, especially as Zirwal has been vocal about a possible NCP merger, an idea that allegedly makes alliance partner BJP jittery.

SORE LOSERS

Nearly three months have passed since the Bihar election, but the state Congress is still droning on about "vote chori". On February 15, when the Nitish Kumar government disbursed Rs 10,000 each to 2.5 million women under its self-employment scheme, state Congress president **Rajesh Kumar** was quick to declare that the regime had acquired a "taste" for buying votes. Perhaps a gentle reminder that the next election will now only be in 2030 would not be amiss.



Kaushik Deka with Ashish Misra, Rahul Noronha, Jumana Shah, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Amitabh Srivastava

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

ROBOTIC TELESURGERIES LONG-DISTANCE OPERATION

Imagine a world where a surgeon does not have to travel to the operating theatre—and a patient does not have to travel across states to find the right specialist. That world edged closer to reality recently at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital in New Delhi where four complex robotic telesurgeries were performed with the patients lying in a Delhi operating theatre while the surgeons operated from Vapi, Gujarat, 1,200 km away.



Over 24 hours, doctors completed four procedures—spanning urology and general surgery—using the Mizzo Endo 4000 telerobotic platform, which allows real-time remote control. Surgeons in Vapi manipulated the robotic instruments, while an on-site team in Delhi handled anaesthesia, patient monitoring and immediate surgical support. Dr Vipin Tyagi, the Robotic Coordinator, said the system delivered "the same precision and surgical confidence across distances as we would present in the operating room".

This effort was not a one-off tech demonstration. It signals a shift in how specialist care could be delivered in India. By combining robotics with stable, high-speed connectivity, robotic telesurgery can bridge the gap between metro-based super-specialists and patients in the smaller towns.

In a country where issues such as long distances and lost wages often delay treatment, remote surgery could ease both travel and financial barriers. Infrastructure and regulation will need to keep pace, but the model offers a practical solution to long-standing access challenges in Indian healthcare.